GatorBait

MAGAZINE



COVER STORY · BUDDY MARTIN

WHO'S QB1 IN AUSTIN?

Philo is hurt. Jones hasn't started a game since Mandarin High. Buddy Martin calls in Ted Lasso to explain the quarterback question, and why calm is not surrender.

BUDDY MARTIN • FRANZ BEARD • EDDIE GILLEY • LOREN MEADOWS

Friday Pregame Edition · Florida at Texas · Week 8 · Austin · Friday, October 16, 2026

GatorBait Media cover art. Photos by Chris Spears

THE GAME

UNRANKED		NO. 7
FLORIDA	AT	**TEXAS**
4-2 · 2-2 SEC		4-1 · 1-1 SEC

Saturday, Oct. 17 · noon ET · ABC
Darrell K Royal-Texas Memorial Stadium, Austin. Sold out

Sunny, 0% rain; 59° at 11 a.m. CT kickoff, 68° by 3 p.m.; NNE wind 10 mph, gusts to 30 (NWS, Oct. 15)

LINE	TOTAL	SERIES	ESPN MATCHUP PREDICTOR
Texas -11.5	51.5	UF trails 1-3-1	Florida 12.5%

ESPN game summary and pickcenter (DraftKings), Oct. 15. Kickoff and TV also on TexasLonghorns.com game center and FloridaGators.com schedule. Forecast: NWS Austin/San Antonio, Oct. 15.

FOUR KEYS

1. Arch Manning vs. the No. 131 pass defense

Florida allows 268.7 passing yards a game, which ESPN ranks 131st nationally, and 29.0 points a game (113th). Arch Manning is 92 of 146 for 1,122 yards, 10 touchdowns and five interceptions, and Texas averages 237.0 passing yards a game. Texas' own defense gives up 168.4 through the air.

2. Jadan Baugh and the run game vs. a Texas D that allows 96.0

Florida runs for 200.3 yards a game at 5.0 a carry, and Jadan Baugh has 110 carries for 672 yards and 12 touchdowns. Texas allows 96.0 rushing yards a game (ESPN rank 19th), 264.4 total yards (12th) and 16.0 points (21st). Texas runs for 142.2 at 3.7 a carry; Hollywood Smothers leads with 237 yards on 53 carries.

3. Turnovers and sacks

Florida is plus-3 in turnover margin with 10 takeaways and seven giveaways; Texas is plus-1 with eight and seven. Manning has thrown five interceptions, and Texas has taken 12 sacks in five games to Florida's eight in six. On defense Florida has 17 sacks, Jayden Woods leading with 4.5, and Texas has 18, Colin Simmons leading with 9.5.

4. Third downs

Texas' defense has held opponents to 30.4% on third down (21 of 69); Florida's has allowed 46.2% (43 of 93). On offense the teams are close: Florida converts 45.2% (33 of 73) and Texas 44.6% (33 of 74).

ESPN 2026 team statistics, national ranks and game-summary leaders, Oct. 15 (Florida six games, Texas five)

TALE OF THE TAPE

Season, per game: Florida through six games, Texas through five

	FLORIDA	TEXAS
Points scored	41.7	31.4
Total yards	473.8	379.2
Rushing yards	200.3	142.2
Yards a carry	5	3.7
Passing yards	273.5	237
Points allowed	29	16
Rush yards allowed	124.3	96
Pass yards allowed	268.7	168.4
Third down %	45.2	44.6
Opp. third down %	46.2	30.4
Possession (minutes)	32.2	31.1

ESPN 2026 team statistics, Oct. 15 (possession minutes figured from ESPN's season possession seconds divided by games played)

THE SERIES

FIVE MEETINGS, ONE GATOR WIN

Texas leads 3-1-1 in five meetings that began with a 7-7 tie in Austin on Oct. 25, 1924. Florida's only win is the latest: 29-21 in Gainesville on Oct. 4, 2025. Texas won 49-17 in Austin on Nov. 9, 2024, and Florida is 0-2-1 in Austin.

AVAILABILITY

ESPN lists no injuries for either team as of Thursday, Oct. 15. The official SEC availability report posts Friday on FloridaGators.com.

COVER STORY · BUDDY MARTIN

QB1 PHILO HURT. QB2 JONES TO START? EXPLAINED BY THAT GREAT FOOTBALL MIND TED LASSO

BY BUDDY MARTIN Oct. 15, 2026



> **"HE DOESN'T MIND HIS PLAYERS ENJOYING SUCCESS. HE JUST DOESN'T WANT THEM MOVING INTO IT AND BUYING FURNITURE."**



Photo Credit - Chris Spears Gatorbait Magazine

By Buddy Martin

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THE LEAD · FRANZ BEARD

PHILO'S INJURY COULD GIVE TRAMELL JONES JR. HIS OPENING

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 14, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Aaron Philo, No. 12, at left, and Tramell Jones Jr., No. 9, at right, on Florida's sideline against South Carolina on Oct. 10, 2026. Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

On June 2, 1925, Wally Pipp suffered what has become known as the most famous headache in history. Legend has it that Pipp asked for the day off because of a raging headache, so New York Yankees manager Miller Huggins replaced him in the starting lineup with Lou Gehrig, who went 3-for-5 against the Washington Senators.

It was years before Gehrig relinquished his job as the Yankees' first baseman (2,130 consecutive games played). Pipp was sold to Cincinnati in 1926.

When it comes to University of Florida football, there have been a couple of notable injuries in recent years.

In 2019, Feleipe Franks dislocated his ankle at Kentucky with the Gators trailing 21-10 late in the third quarter. Kyle Trask led the Gators to a stunning comeback for a 29-21 UF win and never looked back. He started the rest of the year and in 2020 finished fourth in Heisman Trophy voting.

In 2024, Graham Mertz had the Gators teetering on the verge of an upset of Tennessee in Knoxville when he tore an ACL. Freshman DJ Lagway filled in the rest of the way as the Gators dropped a 23-17 decision to the Vols, but Lagway would go on to lead the Gators to an 8-5 record, their only winning record other than the Trask-led Gators 8-4 mark in 2020 during the six seasons from 2020 through 2025.

It is unfortunate, but so often one man's injury is another man's opportunity. It was reported Wednesday that Florida (4-2, 2-2 SEC) starting quarterback Aaron Philo's availability is uncertain for Saturday's game in Austin against No. 7 Texas (4-1, 1-1 SEC). If Philo is unable to answer the bell against Texas (noon ET, ABC), Tramell Jones Jr. will be the starter. Jones is next in line as the Gators prep for the Longhorns.

The Gainesville Sun reported that Philo suffered a shoulder injury in the Gators' 38-19 loss to South Carolina, a game that was finished by sophomore Jones. There has been no indication if it was Philo's right (throwing) or left shoulder, which could be the deciding factor in whether or not he is fit to play.

If Philo is a no-go and Jones plays very well, either leading the Gators to what would be a stunning upset or a white-knuckle finish, would Sumrall abide by that unwritten football rule that you don't lose your starting job because of an injury or would he roll the dice and go with Jones against Georgia in two weeks?

The old football rule sounds very good and reeks of loyalty but doesn't necessarily fly in this modern age when coaches are paid millions. There aren't that many seven-figure jobs to be had, so if a replacement QB steps in and has a hot hand, is he relegated back to the bench when the injured player is healthy again?

Sumrall has said more than once that he believes the Gators can win with either Philo or Jones at quarterback, but certainly experience favors Philo, who has started all six games at UF including two on the road in SEC play (Auburn and Missouri).

Jones has played in seven games, all of them off the bench. His career stats are 44-for-64 passing (68.75 percent) for 443 yards (6.92 yards per attempt) with four touchdown passes and two interceptions. In his last two SEC games, Jones is 11-13 for 126 yards with one TD and one interception.

COUNTDOWN TO FIRING DAY: OCTOBER 15, 2026 EDITION

EXTINCT SPECIES LIST

Keep an eye on what happens with Rutgers at Maryland and Florida State at Miami.

ON LIFE SUPPORT

Mike Norvell, Florida State: The Seminoles led Louisville 14-0 in the first quarter, then lost the next three quarters 44-6. That was bad. What promises to happen this weekend at Miami will be even worse. The boosters want Norvell gone, but the buyout remains a major obstacle. That leaves two choices: Keep Norvell another year (bad) or convince Jimbo to coach for $1 million to $2 million for the next five years (bad idea, but better than keeping him).

Dave Doeren, North Carolina State: The next six games are actually winnable but anything more than 3-3 or 4-2 would be a miracle. He has won more than he's lost but the faithful want more than bowl games in scenic, exotic locales like Shreveport. He will be gone with a losing season and could be gone with a break-even record.

Mike Locksley, Maryland: If the Turtles figure out a way to lose to Rutgers this weekend, Locks could be the first coaching domino to fall. Maryland has given up 182 points during its four-game skid. Only Saturday's game with Rutgers looks remotely winnable. Maryland is a former ACC school trying to compete in the Big Ten and it's just not working out. Locksley's buyout is cheap comparatively speaking.

Greg Schiano, Rutgers: A 1-6 record the rest of the way would be a small miracle. The one chance is Saturday at Maryland. This could be a loser gets voted off the island kind of game. The only thing that will stand in the way of Schiano getting pink-slipped is the buyout - which is roughly $18.5 million after the 2026 season.

Bill O'Brien, Boston College: There are a couple of saving graces working in O'Brien's favor. First off, BC might spend less on football than any power conference team, so the fact he has the Eagles competitive could help him keep his job at least one more year. Second, the Eagles are competitive. They've lost two straight to Virginia Tech and SMU by a combined 16 points. Virginia Tech had to rally for two fourth quarter touchdowns to win. If any of the remaining teams other than Notre Dame and Miami blows the Eagles out, however, it could be the end of the line for O'Brien.

Joe Moorhead, Akron: The Zips are 1-5, going absolutely nowhere. He's 14-40 for his career at Akron. He's lasted this long because Akron really doesn't have the money to go through the firing and hiring process even though Moorhead works very cheap. Miami (Ohio) should handle the Zips easily this week but the admin is unlikely to do anything until season's end.

ENDANGERED SPECIES LIST

Steve Sarkisian, Texas: The Longhorns are 4-1, formerly ranked No. 1. The Aggies await in the season finale. Anything less than 10-2 and Sark's job could be on the line. The buyout won't faze the boosters. Only God has more money than the Longhorns.

Shane Beamer, South Carolina: He had one foot out the door last Saturday morning. By Saturday evening, he was off life support and moved to the Endangered Species List. The win over Florida is only a temporary reprieve. Now Beamer has to figure out a way to win four of the next six starting with Tennessee on Oct. 24 in Columbia.

Bill Belichick, North Carolina: Beating Pitt on the road last week renewed hope among the faithful that perhaps Belichick can make the Tar Heels relevant on the national stage. The Heels are 3-2 this year and with the exception of Miami, there isn't a game on the remaining schedule that UNC can't win. All the same, he's got to get the Tar Heels bowl eligible.

Deion Sanders, Colorado: Three straight losses and now Utah and Okie State back-to-back. The Buffs are 2-3 and will struggle to get to six wins. Six will buy another year. Five and things get really dicey.

Dave Aranda, Baylor: The Bears are 4-1 and could be 8-1 before closing out the season with the (at) BYU, Texas Tech, (at) Houston gauntlet. Seven wins and Aranda's off the hook. Eight or nine and he gets a contract extension.

Lincoln Riley, Southern Cal: The Trojans are 6-1 so why is Riley in any kind of trouble. Well, it has everything to do with no championships since he came to LA from Oklahoma. His tenure this year will be judged by what he does in games against Ohio State, Indiana and UCLA.

Butch Jones, Arkansas State: He's 2-4 but Jones has made a habit of winning more than he loses in the second half of the season. He probably won't get canned this year unless the Red Wolves go completely in the tank, but if he doesn't get to six wins in the regular season his seat will be very hot to start 2027.

Brent Venables, Oklahoma: The win over Texas was a shocker. The next three games - Kentucky, (at) Mississippi State and South Carolina - are must win games. A 6-2 record heading into November will have the Sooners in line for a CFP at-large.

Dabo Swinney, Clemson: The Tigers are 3-2, but blessed with seven remaining games that are all very winnable. Clemson really isn't 10 wins good, but the ACC is that bad this year.

Fran Brown, Syracuse: The schedule is brutal and there aren't many potential wins to be had. The Orange are 2-3 and heading for 3-9 or 4-8. Brown won't get fired this year, but he will be on the hot seat next year.

SATURDAY IN THE SEC: THE SOOTHSAYER'S PICKS

Picks by Franz Beard, from The Soothsayer. Kickoffs and TV: ESPN scoreboard. All times ET. Florida's line from ESPN.

TIME (ET)	GAME	TV	LINE
Noon	**Florida (4-2) at No. 7 Texas (4-1)** Texas by three TDs or more	**ABC**	**TEX -11.5 · O/U 51.5**
Noon	No. 16 Mississippi State (4-1) at No. 22 LSU (4-2)	ESPN/Disney+	
1 p.m.	The Citadel (2-4) at Texas A&M (3-3)	SECN+	
3:30 p.m.	Auburn (3-2) at No. 1 Georgia (6-0)	ESPN	
3:30 p.m.	No. 6 Alabama (5-1) at No. 14 Tennessee (5-1) Brace for a white-knuckle finish	ABC	
3:30 p.m.	No. 13 Missouri (5-1) at No. 9 Ole Miss (4-1) Heart says Mizzou; mind says Rebels	SEC Network	
7 p.m.	Arkansas (2-4) at Vanderbilt (3-3)	ESPN2	
7:30 p.m.	No. 15 Kentucky (5-1) at Oklahoma (3-2)	SEC Network	

Kickoffs, TV, records and rankings: ESPN SEC scoreboard for Oct. 17, checked against the AP Top 25 (Week 7) and ESPN SEC standings, Oct. 15. Florida-Texas line and total: ESPN pickcenter (DraftKings), Oct. 15. Picks: Franz Beard, The Soothsayer, Oct. 16 (/post/the-soothsayer-texas-big-unless-the-uf-defense-finds-an-exorcist).

HOW TO WATCH

KICKOFF	Saturday, Oct. 17, noon ET (11 a.m. CT)
TV	ABC
STREAM	ESPN app, with a TV-provider login
RADIO	ESPN Radio (national feed). Gator IMG Sports Network details not yet confirmed
WHERE	Darrell K Royal-Texas Memorial Stadium, Austin. Sold out

Sources: ESPN broadcast listing and game summary; TexasLonghorns.com game center (11 a.m. CT, ABC, sold out); FloridaGators.com schedule (12 p.m. ET)

FRANZ BEARD · THE SOOTHSAYER

THE SOOTHSAYER: TEXAS BIG UNLESS THE UF DEFENSE FINDS AN EXORCIST

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 16, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

"Out in the ocean, a rope is put around a man's neck. The other end of the rope is attached to an old jukebox and it is thrown overboard. The man invariably follows." – From "The Gang That Couldn't Shoot Straight," a novel by Jimmy Breslin.

This is what the Florida-Texas game (noon ET, ABC) feels like. Florida is the man with the rope around his neck. Texas is the jukebox about to be tossed overboard in waters inhabited by great white sharks several miles from the nearest beach. The Gators (4-2, 2-2 SEC) have plunged from college football's surprise darlings to here we go again thanks to a defense that seems bent on channeling its inner Todd Grantham and an offensive line that evokes memories of batters who faced Sandy Koufax in his prime. Whiff! Texas (4-1, 1-1 SEC), meanwhile, is the jukebox. The seventh-ranked Longhorns have an offense that desperately needs to get well and who better than the worst defense in the SEC to have the same healing properties of a few days soaking in the hot springs at the Arenal volcano in Costa Rica. Texas also has a defense coordinated by Will Muschamp, who remembers all too well being dumped by the Gators in 2014 when he was the head coach. The multiple millions of buyout money have not soothed that wound.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/the-soothsayer-texas-big-unless-the-uf-defense-finds-an-exorcist

BUDDY MARTIN · MEMBERS

QB1 PHILO HURT. QB2 JONES TO START? EXPLAINED BY THAT GREAT FOOTBALL MIND TED LASSO

BY BUDDY MARTIN Oct. 15, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

By Buddy Martin

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Subscribe to gatorbaitmedia.com to keep reading this exclusive post.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/qb1-philo-hurt-qb2-jones-to-start-explained-by-that-great-football-mind-ted-lasso

EDDIE GILLEY

SO YOU'RE SAYING THERE'S A CHANCE!?

BY EDDIE GILLEY Oct. 15, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Well, the low scoring Longhorns have their struggles, too.

I wrote earlier in the week about the similarities of the stats between UF and UM last weekend in every category but the one that matters. Facing the Texas Longhorns on the road in Austin is a tough task for a team that hasn't played well in the last two weeks.

The Gators hit the road as a 10.5-point underdog. Is there anything that points to a possible Gator victory?

The Gators will face the #3 total defense in the SEC in the Will Muschamp led Texas defense. They are ranked either third or fourth in the conference in every category. They are the #13 ranked defense in college football.

That task is a daunting task by itself. Throw in the possibility of having Tramell Jones Jr. making his first road SEC start and the hill gets a little higher.

Add in the uncertainty of Vernell Brown III and the health of Eric Singleton and the road gets even more steep.

The offense couldn't gain any traction on the road in Columbia, Mo. and didn't do much better against the guys from Columbia e

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/so-you-re-saying-there-s-a-chance-1

GAME WEEK

REPORT: AARON PHILO'S STATUS UNCERTAIN FOR FLORIDA'S TRIP TO TEXAS

BY BRENDEN MARTIN Oct. 14, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Aaron Philo was limited at practice Wednesday, according to On3. Tramell Jones Jr. would be next in line if Philo cannot play.

Aaron Philo runs against Auburn on Sept. 19, 2026. Archival photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

GAINESVILLE - Florida's trip to Texas now includes a question about whether Aaron Philo will be available to run the offense Saturday.

On3 reported Wednesday, citing GatorsOnline reporter Zach Abolverdi, that Philo threw at practice but was limited by an injury. His availability for the game is uncertain, according to that report.

Tramell Jones Jr. would be next in line if Philo cannot play. The report does not establish that Philo has been ruled out, and an injury-driven change would be different from a decision to replace him as Florida's starter.

The Gators, 4-2 overall and 2-2 in the SEC, visit No. 7 Texas on Saturday, Oct. 17. Kickoff in Austin is noon ET on ABC.

Philo completed 21 of 28 passes for 227 yards, one touchdown and one interception in Florida's 38-19 loss to South Carolina last Saturday. Jones entered in the fourth quarter and finished 6 of 8 for 40 yards with an interception.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/report-aaron-philo-s-status-uncertain-for-florida-s-trip-to-texas

FRANZ BEARD · THOUGHTS OF THE DAY

THOUGHTS OF THE DAY: MUSCHAMP, MANNING AND THE TRIP TO TEXAS

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 14, 2026



GatorBait Media illustration

GatorBait editorial illustration.

A few thoughts to jump start your Wednesday morning:

It isn't just the Florida Gators (4-2, 2-2 SEC) against the No. 7 Texas Longhorns (4-1, 1-1 SEC) Saturday in Austin (noon ET, 11 a.m. CT, ABC). It is the Gators against ghosts of the past.

On the Texas sideline coaching up the defense will be coordinator Will Muschamp, the same guy who dialed up the defense at Auburn to hand the Gators their only loss on their way to a national championship in 2006. He was Florida's head coach from 2011-14, coaching some fabulous defenses and leaving behind NFL-quality talent that helped Jim McElwain win successive SEC East titles. Success faded as that talent moved on to the NFL.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/thoughts-of-the-day-october-14-2026

And then there is Arch Manning, grandson of Archie, nephew of Peyton and Eli. Given the bloodlines, perhaps no high school quarterback has ever arrived in college with as much hype. He's 16-4 as a starting quarterback, with 5,254 career passing yards, 45 touchdown passes and 14 interceptions, plus a 6-2 record against ranked teams. But no one in the country gets more criticism if the Longhorns lose a game.

FRANZ BEARD

PHILO IS THE FLORIDA QUARTERBACK, AT LEAST FOR NOW

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 13, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Because it is universally described as the single most important position in all of team sports, when it comes to football fingers immediately point to the quarterback whenever things go south, which they have the last two weeks for the Florida Gators (4-2, 2-2 SEC). Aaron Philo, whose numbers were just a shade under brilliant in Florida's 4-0 September have taken a serious plunge in losses to Missouri and South Carolina. In the four wins, Philo was 76-104 passing, good for 1,091 yards (10.49 yards per attempt) and eight touchdowns. Two of his three interceptions were deflections by a wide receiver who should have caught the football. In the losses, Philo is 53-75 for 550 yards (7.33 yards per attempt), three touchdowns and two picks.

The yards per pass attempt is the single most revealing stat in football and a three yards per attempt differential between games one through four and the last two says plenty about an offense that scored more than 40 points each ga/me in September to one that has produced a combined 36 points in October. The Gators were a top five offense in September, averaging more than 523 yards per game, but that plunged significantly starting with Missouri (325 yards) and got only slightly better against South Carolina (387).

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/philo-is-the-florida-quarterback-at-least-for-now

BUDDY MARTIN

BUDDY BLOG: A GATOR ASS-WHIPPING, WITH BOWL PROJECTIONS IN THE ASHES

BY BUDDY MARTIN Oct. 13, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Florida's sideline during the South Carolina game at Ben Hill Griffin Stadium on Oct. 10, 2026.

Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

Trying to find two more wins is going to take patience and ibuprofen

By Buddy Martin

It wasn't the Grim Reaper. He generally has the courtesy to finish the job. South Carolina merely left Florida lying there with six games remaining and a fan base wondering whether the season came with a refund policy.

This was a good old-fashioned ass-whipping, delivered on a particularly bad Saturday for the Gators to discover they were the ones furnishing the ass.

A punch in the mouth? Too charitable. A punch in the mouth suggests you might still be standing afterward, perhaps considering a response.

This was a right cross, an uppercut, a gut punch and a kick in the family jewels. Apparently, South Carolina had purchased the deluxe package.

For the boxing crowd, think jab–cross–left hook. The classic 1–2–3: two straight shots followed by a hook that makes you reconsider your recreational interests.

Checkers, perhaps? Something with a chair.

Or the right cross–left hook–right cross, which dispenses with introductions and gets directly to the damage. Then the uppercut–left hook: one coming up, the other coming around, neither interested in your preseason expectations.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/buddy-blog-a-gator-ass-whipping-with-bowl-projections-in-the-ashes

FRANZ BEARD

TEXAS OPENS AS A 10-POINT FAVORITE AGAINST FLORIDA

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 12, 2026



GatorBait Media illustration

GatorBait editorial illustration.

Combine a September that far exceeded everyone's expectations with the last two weekends and you have a plot straight out of a Roadrunner cartoon. You know how it goes.

Wile E. Coyote orders a rocket from Acme, mounts it and lights a fuse in order to catch up with the Roadrunner. The Roadrunner stops at the edge of a canyon, Wile goes flying by and a thousand feet above the canyon floor, the rocket fizzles out. Wile and the rocket fall to the bottom of the canyon with a loud crash.

Isn't that what Florida's 4-0 September and October's 0-2 at the hands of Missouri and South Carolina feels like? The rocket has fizzled out and unless Jon Sumrall and his staff can reignite it, there will be a crash on a canyon floor. This is when we find out what the Gators are made of.

Adversity has struck not once, but twice and on successive weekends to boot.

Sumrall saw it coming, which is why he warned after the Ole Miss win, "You have to humble yourself or you will be humbled." The Gators have been humbled now and how they respond will dictate the last six weeks of the regular season.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/texas-opens-as-a-10-point-favorite-against-florida

EDDIE GILLEY

NUMBERS DON'T LIE

BY EDDIE GILLEY Oct. 12, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Numbers don't lie except when they do! When we got into the media room after the game on Saturday, the staff handed us a stat sheet. I couldn't believe the numbers could be accurate. That wasn't the game I had just watched with my eyes. It couldn't have been that game. Let me show you what I mean.

First downs: South Carolina 22, Florida 20

Rushing yards: South Carolina 114, Florida 120

Passing yards: South Carolina 279, Florida 267

Total yards: South Carolina 393, Florida 387

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/numbers-don-t-lie

Do those numbers look like they belong to a 38-19 score?

What in the world happened to make this game a lopsided affair that ended in a statistical draw? The biggest number might be the number 3, as in 3 Gator turnovers. Philo fumbled on a drive deep in the Gamecocks' end of the field to stop one drive. The interception from Philo late in the second quarter gave South Carolina a short field and a missed opportunity to stop them on third down led to a touchdown for SC. A missed fourth down in the fourth quarter gave them another short field that led to a quick touchdown for the visitors. The interception thrown by Jones was also in the SC end of the field although by that time the game was really over.

BUDDY MARTIN

AN ANATOMY OF TOTAL GATOR COLLAPSE: A SWAMP STREWN WITH BROKEN DREAMS

BY BUDDY MARTIN Oct. 12, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Not even the passion of the HBC could help. (Chris Spears photo)

By Buddy Martin

Two weeks ago, Florida was unbeaten, ranked No. 8 and looking like a football team that had discovered something. An identity. A formula. Maybe even a future.

Now the Gators have disappeared from both the AP Top 25 and the Coaches Poll, and the rankings might be the least troubling thing that has vanished.

The running game is missing. The offensive imagination seems to have gone with it. The defense has become accommodating. And those offensive and defensive lines we were praising as the foundation of this team? Apparently, the foundation needs inspecting.

Missouri, 45-17. South Carolina, 38-19. Right before God, country and Steve Spurrier. At his Monday presser, Jon Sumrall looked composed after a fiery morning practice, somewhat revitalized and gritty while still looking for answers.

Whatever composure that Sumrall appeared to have lost – some of you were going by his body language – he had gotten back by his press conference on Monday and he made it very clear: nobody has been trying to tame him or change his sometimes salty language. He was scoffing at the notion and doubled down on his vow to never change his personality.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/an-anatomy-of-total-gator-collapse-a-swamp-strewn-with-broken-dreams

BEST SHOTS

From South Carolina 38, Florida 19 · Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media



Out of the tunnel



Stockton, 59 yards



Albert leads the way



Sumrall walks out



Eyes forward

Next up: an open date, then Georgia in Atlanta on Oct. 31.

GatorBait Magazine, Friday Pregame Edition, Friday, October 16, 2026. Independent Florida Gators coverage. ESPN game summary (event 401856724), scoreboard, team statistics, rosters and AP Top 25 (Week 7), DraftKings line via ESPN pickcenter, all pulled Oct. 15, 2026 (about 7 p.m. ET); NWS Austin/San Antonio forecast issued Oct. 15; FloridaGators.com series history and schedule; TexasLonghorns.com game center. The line and forecast can move before Saturday. Published by GatorBait Media, www.gatorbaitmedia.com.